Financial Literacy in Bangalore Gig Workers

An Empirical Analysis

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Author Note

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Abstract

This study examines the level of financial literacy among gig workers in Bangalore. Gig workers often face vulnerabilities due to a lack of job security and benefits. Using the "Capability Approach" model (Sen, 1999) this study underpins financial literacy as an important skill for gig workers to reach their financial goals. Based on previous research on financial literacy in India, focus group discussions were used to administer a 5-question quiz to 40 security guards, who represented gig workers in this study. The quiz assessed financial literacy across three main areas: Numerical Ability, Financial Knowledge, and Financial Awareness. These areas together indicated the participants' overall financial literacy. The main goal of this study was to find demographic factors that best predicted financial literacy levels. Using Bayesian logistic regression, the findings suggest that migrant workers had much lower odds of being financially literate compared to locals and scored particularly low on financial awareness. Age also mattered, with participants aged 30 to 39 showing lower skills in numeracy and knowledge than those under 30. These findings emphasize the need for targeted financial education and policy actions that address the unique challenges faced by migrant gig workers.

Keywords: financial literacy, gig workers, Bayesian logistic regression, financial awareness

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Over the past few years, work has changed a lot. More people are taking on gig work, which means short-term, flexible jobs instead of traditional, permanent positions. Sopan (2023) noted “For gig workers, financial literacy is not only a valuable asset but a necessity”. Gig work includes delivery drivers, freelance designers, and security guards. These jobs often lack the stability, benefits, and social protections, such as health insurance and pensions, that come with full-time contracts, making them more risky. Higher financial literacy was associated with greater financial resilience, specifically in individuals working in high-risk economic sectors (Elomari, 2025; Katnic et al., 2024). Lusardi and Mitchell (2011) explain financial literacy as "the ability to process financial information and make informed decisions about financial planning, wealth accumulation, debt, and pensions" (p. 352). They identify three main skills that define financial literacy: performing compound interest calculations, understanding inflation, and recognizing the importance of spreading out risk.

Research by Goyal and Kumar (2021) shows that financial literacy is a concern in both developed and developing countries. Lusardi and Mitchell's (2011) foundational survey asked people about the three main skills and found that only about one-third could answer correctly, even in advanced economies like Germany and Japan. This reveals a widespread issue. Praveen and Elango (2025) reviewed literature suggesting that certain demographic groups, particularly women, younger individuals, the elderly, and those with lower education levels, tend to have lower financial literacy.

In India, Dash and Ranjan (2023) analyzed state-level data from the All-India Debt and Investment Survey (2019). They observed significant regional differences in financial literacy levels, with people from southern states showing higher literacy compared to those from northern or eastern states.

This study, conducted as part of the IISc Sustainability Research Lab[1], focuses on gig workers in Bangalore, a vulnerable part of the unorganized sector. This line of inquiry follows recent discourse on financial well-being (Urs, 2025), which emphasizes the challenges and opportunities in structuring financial interventions for the unorganized sector. The rationale for this focus is supported by Zaimovic et al. (2023), who highlight that many factors influencing financial literacy have not been studied enough. This study contributes to this area by studying migrant workers among gig workers who face specific challenges, such as language barriers and being far from traditional support systems. Al-Afeef and Alsmadi (2025) found that higher digital literacy helps people make better financial decisions. This is especially relevant in India's context as the financial system becomes more digital, with the rise of UPI payments, online wallets, and the government's push for digitization. A lack of digital literacy can worsen the problem of low financial literacy, leaving these vulnerable groups open to misinformation and fraud. Van Rooij et al. (2011) show that low financial literacy stops households from using long-term wealth-building methods like the stock market. This finding is relevant for gig workers, who lack the stability, benefits, and social protections provided by traditional jobs.

This research utilizes an adapted version of Lusardi and Mitchell's framework, modifying the questions to be culturally and contextually relevant to the participants. Instead of asking about stocks versus mutual funds, financial products like chit funds, insurance, and savings accounts, which are more common in their financial lives were included. The primary research question of this study was: *Which demographic factor best explains financial literacy levels*

[1] See https://www.linkedin.com/posts/iisc-sustainability-research-lab_how-financially-literate-are-gig-casual-activity for details on the lab's initiative

among gig workers in Bangalore? By zooming in on this specific population, this study's findings contribute to the broader discussions on financial literacy and vulnerability.

The paper is structured into four main sections. The opening section provides a concise overview of the gig economy in India, setting the contextual foundation for the study. This is followed by a review of the literature on financial literacy and its measurement, with specific attention to frameworks relevant to the research context. The subsequent section presents an in-depth account of the research design and findings, detailing the methodological approach and empirical insights. The paper concludes by outlining key limitations of the study and offering directions for future research.

Gig economy in India

The context of the gig economy in India is defined by its rapid expansion as a market structure based on short-term, flexible, and freelance employment arrangements, often mediated by digital platforms that connect independent workers directly with customers and businesses. This economic shift began taking shape in the early 2000s and has been dramatically accelerated by rapid technological progress, increased digitalisation, changing employer preferences for flexible staffing, and the widespread availability of low-cost internet and smartphones. Initially attracting highly skilled professionals (such as IT consultants and graphic designers), the market was quickly democratized by the emergence of app-based services (including Uber, Ola, Swiggy, and Zomato), extending opportunities to low-skilled laborers and making it a significant substitute for regular employment in a nation contending with high unemployment and underemployment (Roy & Shrivastava, 2020). India currently holds the largest supply of platform workers globally, commanding 20% of the world's share, and its domestic gig workforce, which numbered 7.7 million (2020-2021), is projected to expand significantly, potentially reaching 23.5 million workers by 2029-30. This growth is expected to create 90 million jobs and contribute 1.25% of India's GDP by 2030 (NITI Aayog, 2022). The latest Poverty and Equity Brief from World Bank hails significant progress made by India to eliminate poverty with recent data indicating self-employment accounting for 53% of paid employment (World Bank, 2025). However, the Indian gig economy operates within the structural constraints of the country’s large informal labor market, leading to a high degree of informality characterized by job insecurity, unpredictable income, and a lack of essential traditional benefits such as health insurance and retirement plans. A critical aspect of this context is the legal classification of workers primarily as independent contractors, which places them outside the protection of established labor laws, leaving them vulnerable to the stringent algorithmic control and opaque policies exerted by the digital platforms (Surie, 2021). Therefore, investing in financial literacy and awareness is crucial as the fundamental lack of income stability makes financial planning difficult for gig workers, particularly given the unpredictable nature of their monthly wages. Financial preparation and foresight are essential administrative skills needed by independent workers to manage the risk of their work. The aim of this research project is to measure the current literacy levels of these workers so that a suitable intervention can be designed in the future.

Literature Review

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) plays an active role in promoting financial literacy through various initiatives and campaigns. In 2019, it carried out the “Financial Literacy and Inclusion Survey” to assess how financially literate Indian adults are and to see how these levels differ across states, urban and rural areas, and different socio-economic groups; a similar survey was first conducted in 2013, using the OECD’s definition and measurement approach for financial literacy.

Several researchers have also tried to define and measure financial literacy in India in different ways. Gunther and Ghosh (2018), using a 2016 survey, measured financial literacy through three components: financial knowledge, financial attitude, and financial behavior. This is captured via specific sets of questions, and weighted attitude and knowledge at 27 per cent each, with the remaining weight assigned to behavior. Gaurav and Singh (2012) relied on two indicators, financial aptitude and debt literacy, while Aggarwal et al. (2015) applied the widely used approach developed by Van Rooij et al. (2011) to the Indian context. These works suggest that financial literacy is often analyzed based on three dimensions: financial knowledge, financial attitude, and financial behavior. Financial attitude describes an individual’s beliefs related to spending and investing. Financial behavior relates to actions taken with funds.

According to OECD (2023), financial knowledge is described as a key component of financial literacy. It is crucial for individuals to compare financial products and services and make appropriate, well-informed financial decisions. Higher financial knowledge is correlated with better financial management and planning practices. It relates to understanding concepts like savings, investments, and interest rates suggesting that intellectual understanding of finance-related concepts necessary for decision making form the basis of financial knowledge (Huston, 2010). According to financial literacy research, understanding core concepts such as interest compounding, inflation, and risk diversification is central to financial capability (Hastings et al., 2013). Studies indicate that globally, very few people can correctly answer basic financial literacy questions, especially concerning risk diversification. Financial literacy generally increases sharply with educational attainment (OECD, 2023).

Financial attitude describes an individual's feelings, beliefs, and values related to spending and investing money. Even when individuals possess financial knowledge and exhibit responsible financial behaviors, the decision to act is largely determined by their attitudes. A person with an affirmative financial attitude is more likely to plan better (Atkinson & Messy, 2011). Financial behavior on the other hand relates to the actions individuals take with their funds, reflecting how they apply their knowledge and attitude in real life. Financial behavior is recognized as the most important determinant of financial literacy because it directly shapes individuals' financial situations and overall well-being. Positive financial behavior is considered a culmination of financial literacy (OECD, 2023). However, the conceptualization of financial literacy often extends to encompass broader concepts like Financial Capability, especially in the context of increasing financial inclusion and digital engagement (Al-Afeef & Alsmadi, 2025). It represents the "ability to act" as well as the "opportunity to act". Financial capability is sometimes used synonymously with financial literacy, although capability is viewed as the manifestation of literacy and the execution of desired behavior (Goyal & Kumar, 2021). Digital financial literacy focuses on the combination of financial literacy and the skills required to use digital devices or technology to handle money transactions. It is considered a prerequisite for the effective use of digital financial services, influencing saving/spending behavior and mitigating risks like over-indebtedness (Al-Afeef & Alsmadi, 2025).

To measure the financial literacy of the gig workers, in this research Lusardi and Mitchell (2011)'s financial literacy measurement survey was adapted to suit the socio-economic context of research participants. However, the underlying objective remained to assess, (i) numeracy and capacity to do calculations related to interest rates, such as compound interest; (ii) understanding of inflation; and (iii) understanding of risk diversification. This standard set of questions and frameworks has been widely used by other governments and academics to measure financial literacy around the world. Dash and Ranjan (2023) have adapted this framework to measure financial literacy in India using the data published by the All India Debt and Investment Survey 2019. While this gives a breakdown of financial literacy across states and sectors, granular data at an individual level is missing. This research addresses this gap by administering the adapted survey to the gig workers in India in a focus group setting so that not only can their financial literacy levels be measured but also provide insights on the adult learning patterns so that suitable interventions can be put in place to improve their literacy levels.

Methods

Participants

For this study, a specific group of gig workers - security guards employed at the Indian Institute of Science (IISc) campus in Bangalore were chosen. In total, about 40 people took part. 37 of them were men and the remaining 3 women. The participants came from different age groups, but the majority were between their mid-20s and late 40s. 50% of them were locals from Bangalore, while others were migrants from states such as West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Bihar and Assam. This group was chosen because security guards represent a typical section of gig workers in the city. Like gig workers they get paid only for the days they show up for work. However, unlike them, they have fixed and limited holidays (1 fixed day per week), and long working hours that are forced upon them. Figure 1 shows participants engaged in a focus group discussion, sharing their experiences with financial management.

Design

The dependent variables in this study were all binary in nature. A binary variable is a specific type of a categorical variable. The main variable was Financially Literate. This was derived using the Financial Literacy Score (FLS) which was measured using a 5 question quiz designed for the study. Each correct answer was given one point with no deductions for incorrect answers. The participants were considered Financially Literate, if they scored 3 or more on the quiz.

The five questions covered three broad skill areas: two questions to assess the participant's Numerical Ability (like interest rate problems), two questions to assess the participant's Knowledge (like the effect of inflation), and one question to assess the participant's Awareness (like the importance of tracking expenses). Table 1 lists the 5 questions used in this study.

Each of the skill areas was also treated as a separate binary dependent variable in this study. They were defined as Numeracy, Knowledge, Awareness. A participant was considered proficient in a given skill, if they answered all of the corresponding questions correctly. For instance, if a participant answered both the numerical ability based questions correctly, they were classified as numerate, and their Numeracy variable was coded as *True*.

The independent variables used to predict were variables like Migrant (categorized as migrant or local to Karnataka), Age (measured in years), Gender (categorized as male or female), and Education_level (categorized as Matriculation/10th Grade, College, or Degree) and Perceived_FLS, which is their own perception of financial awareness (categorized as High or Low).

Materials

This study used a five-question financial literacy quiz, adapted from Lusardi and Mitchell's (2011) well-known questions to suit the participants' context. Additionally, participants completed a demographic survey, providing information on their age, gender, education level, and migrant status. In addition, focus group discussions were conducted with these participants. These sessions involved 7–10 participants, a facilitator, and conversations about money habits, savings, and financial knowledge and challenges. With their consent, discussions were audio-recorded and transcribed live into notes using AI.

Procedure

The study was conducted over two days, August 16 and 17, at the IISc campus, involving 40 security guards in groups of 7-10. Participants were welcomed, given an information sheet and consent form, and then completed a demographic survey and a five-question finance quiz. Following this, a facilitator led a group discussion where participants shared their experiences with money management, financial advice sources, and challenges with banks or digital payments. Volunteers took notes, and sessions were recorded. At the end, participants received refreshments and a small gift, to thank them for their time. Each session lasted about 90 minutes. The demographic survey and the quiz took 20-25 minutes. Sessions were held on weekends for convenience, and the group setting encouraged open conversation. Figure 2 provides a flowchart of the study's method.

The results from the five-question quiz were used to measure the Financial Literacy Score (FLS) - which was the sum total of all the correct answers. While computing FLS, scores for the three individual skill areas - Numerical Ability, Knowledge and Awareness were also computed.

The participants were considered Financially Literate, if their FLS was 3 or more. A participant was considered proficient in a given skill (Numeracy, Knowledge, Awareness), if they answered all of the corresponding questions correctly. Using this coding, the categorical dependent variables for each of the participants was computed.

A regression analysis was conducted to check which of the demographic factors (independent variables) best explained each of the dependent variables. In essence, regression analysis was run four times.

Given the categorical nature of the dependent variables, logistic regression was used. Logistic regression predicts the odds of an outcome. For example, if the outcome is to measure if the participant is Financially Literate or not, the odds would be defined as

$$\text{odds} = \frac{P(\text{Financially Literate})}{1 - P(\text{Financially Literate})}$$

The odds ratio (OR) compares the odds between two groups. For example, the odds ratio for being Financially Literate between 2 groups lets say, Migrant vs. Local would be defined as

$$\text{odds ratio (OR)} = \frac{\text{odds(Migrant)}}{\text{odds(Local)}} = \frac{P(\text{Financially Literate} \mid \text{Migrant})/(1 - P(\text{Financially Literate} \mid \text{Migrant}))}{P(\text{Financially Literate} \mid \text{Local})/(1 - P(\text{Financially Literate} \mid \text{Local}))}$$

However, given the small dataset results from the standard logistic regression were unstable. To overcome this problem, Bayesian logistic regression was used. Bayesian methods allowed to incorporate weakly informative priors, which stabilize estimates and reduce the risk of extreme odds ratios. Results are reported as posterior medians (odds ratio) with 95% credible intervals.

Results

The main research question of this study was: *Which demographic factor best explains financial literacy levels among gig workers in Bangalore?* Since financial literacy is unpacked into three skill based areas, this study tried answering a corollary question: *Which demographic factor best explains each of the skill areas among gig workers in Bangalore?*

Multivariable logistic regression models used in this study estimated four binary outcomes: Financially Literate, Numeracy, Knowledge and Awareness. Predictors included age group, education level, perceived financial literacy, and migrant status.

Given the small sample size (N = 40; events-per-variable often < 3), standard logistic regression failed to converge or produced unstable odds ratios due to quasi-separation. This study therefore relied on Bayesian estimates with weakly informative priors.

Financially Literate

Migrant status was the strongest predictor of overall financial literacy. Migrants had substantially lower odds of achieving a score of three or more compared to locals. The Bayesian estimate indicated OR = 0.05, 95% High Density Interval (HDI) [0.000005, 0.21].

Age group, education level, and perceived financial literacy did not show consistent associations.

Numeracy

Age group emerged as the main factor for numeracy skills. Participants aged 30–39 had lower odds of correctly answering both numeracy questions compared to those under 30. The Bayesian estimate suggested OR = 0.16, 95% HDI [0.001, 0.50].

Other predictors, including migrant status, education, and perceived financial literacy, were not reliably associated with numeracy.

Knowledge

For knowledge, the age pattern was similar to numeracy. Participants aged 30–39 showed markedly lower odds than the <30 group, with a Bayesian OR = 0.10, 95% HDI [0.00002, 0.38].

No consistent associations were observed for education, migrant status, or perceived financial literacy.

Awareness

Awareness showed a distinct demographic pattern, with migrant status strongly predictive. Migrants had much lower odds of correctly answering the awareness question, with a Bayesian OR = 0.05, 95% HDI [0.000005, 0.21].

Summary

Table 2 summarizes the results of the research and highlights two key patterns. First, migrant workers consistently demonstrated lower awareness and overall financial literacy compared to locals. Second, participants aged 30–39 performed worse in numeracy and knowledge than younger participants under 30.

Education and self-perceived financial literacy did not reliably predict performance across any of the domains.

Table 2

Summary of Bayesian Logistic Regression Results (Odds Ratios and 95% HDIs)

Outcome	Predictor	OR	95% HDI
Financially Literate	Migrant (vs. Local)	0.05	[0.000005, 0.21]
	Other predictors	—	—
Numeracy (Cal1_bin)	Age 30–39 (vs. <30)	0.16	[0.001, 0.50]
	Other predictors	—	—
Knowledge (Know1_bin)	Age 30–39 (vs. <30)	0.10	[0.00002, 0.38]
	Other predictors	—	—
Awareness (Awa1)	Migrant (vs. Local)	0.05	[0.000005, 0.21]
	Other predictors	—	—

Discussion

This study examined financial literacy among gig workers in Bangalore, focusing on Overall Financial Literacy and three specific skill areas: Numeracy, Knowledge, and Awareness. The results revealed two main patterns. First, migrant workers were significantly less likely than local workers to demonstrate overall financial literacy and awareness of basic financial concepts. Second, participants aged 30–39 consistently scored lower on numeracy and knowledge questions compared to younger participants under 30. Education level and self-perceived financial literacy were not reliable predictors of performance in any domain.

These results suggest that both *migrant status* and *age* are important factors in determining financial literacy among gig workers. The finding that migrant workers scored significantly lower on overall financial literacy and, specifically, on financial awareness aligns with the broader regional trends identified by Dash and Ranjan (2023). The lower performance of migrants may reflect structural barriers, such as language challenges or lack of a trusted support group to acquire formal financial education. Similarly, the age-related differences in Numeracy and Knowledge could indicate a generational gap, where younger workers have had more exposure to financial concepts, perhaps through digital literacy or informal learning.

The results of this study can be viewed through the lens of Sen's "Capability Approach," which posits that well-being should be measured by an individual's capabilities—the real opportunities they have to achieve their desired functionings or state of being. In this context, financial literacy is a fundamental capability. This study's findings highlight how a lack of this capability, rooted in a person's migrant status or age, can restrict their ability to achieve key functionings, such as securing their future, managing financial risks, and making informed investment decisions. For the migrant gig workers in this study, their lower financial literacy scores suggest that despite the freedom to engage in the gig economy, their capability to navigate its financial complexities is limited by systemic factors. The age-related disparities also point to a similar dynamic, where a lack of financial knowledge among older workers restricts their capability to engage effectively with modern financial products. Thus, the observed disparities are not merely about a lack of personal knowledge but rather a reflection of unequal capabilities that are influenced by demographic and structural inequalities.

These findings emphasize that disparities in financial literacy are not purely individual shortcomings but reflect broader social and structural barriers, such as language challenges or lack of prior exposure to formal financial education. Recognizing these patterns is crucial for designing interventions that support vulnerable groups.

To address the disparities identified in this study, targeted interventions could be implemented to empower vulnerable gig workers. These initiatives should focus on reducing structural barriers and providing accessible resources. Suggested interventions include the development of financial literacy mobile applications specifically designed for migrant workers, in multiple regional languages to overcome communication barriers. To leverage the increasing digitization of finance, the creation of digital financial tools and apps with simplified instructions, visual guides, and support in vernacular languages would be particularly effective in enhancing accessibility and promoting self-guided learning.

Additionally, community-based peer education programs or employer-supported programs could build trust and provide relevant, context-specific advice.

These interventions aim to reduce structural barriers and empower marginalized groups to make informed financial decisions. They collectively aim to shift the burden of financial literacy from individual initiative to a more supportive, structurally inclusive system.

Implications

The study highlights the importance of considering demographic factors when assessing financial literacy. Policymakers, NGOs, and employers should prioritize inclusive financial education, particularly for migrant workers and older gig workers. Programs designed with equity in mind can improve financial well-being, reduce vulnerability to exploitation, and support long-term economic inclusion.

Limitations

This study has several limitations. First, the sample size was small ($N = 40$), which limits generalizability and may have contributed to unstable estimates in standard logistic regression. Second, the sample included a specific subset of gig workers (security guards at IISc), which may not represent the broader gig economy in Bangalore. Third, the cross-sectional design prevents causal inference; observed associations may reflect unmeasured confounders such as prior financial experience, literacy in the local language, or family support structures.

Future Research

Future research should expand to larger and more diverse samples of gig workers across sectors to validate these findings. Longitudinal studies could explore how financial literacy develops over time, particularly among migrants adjusting to new environments. Additionally, experimental interventions, such as randomized workshops or app-based training programs, could evaluate the effectiveness of tailored financial literacy initiatives.

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Appendix

Table 1

5 Question Quiz

#	Skill Area	Question	Options	Answer
1	Numerical Ability	Ravi takes a loan of ₹ 10,000 from his neighbour and agrees to pay 3% monthly interest. How much interest will he pay every month?	₹ 350 ₹ 300 ₹ 30 Do not know	₹ 300
2	Numerical Ability	Suppose Krishna had ₹ 1000 in a savings account and the interest rate was 5% per year. After 5 years, how much do you think you would have in the account if he left the money to grow:	More than ₹ 1050 Exactly ₹ 1050 Less than ₹ 1050 Do not know	More than ₹ 1050
3	Financial Knowledge	Meera kept ₹ 5000 in a fixed deposit account that had 5% interest rate. If the inflation is 6% when she withdraws the money, would she be able to buy:	More than today Exactly, the same as today Less than today Do not know	Less than today
4	Financial Knowledge	Raju invests all his monthly savings in one chit fund. Ranganna spreads his monthly savings through a chit fund, a bank savings account, and an insurance policy. Whose investments are less risky?	Raju Ranganna Both have the same risk level Do not know	Ranganna

5	Financial Awareness	Do you think the following statement is **true or false**? "Tracking your daily expenses can help you avoid running out of money before the month ends."	True False Do not Know	True

Figure 1

Focus group discussion. Participants shared their experiences with financial management

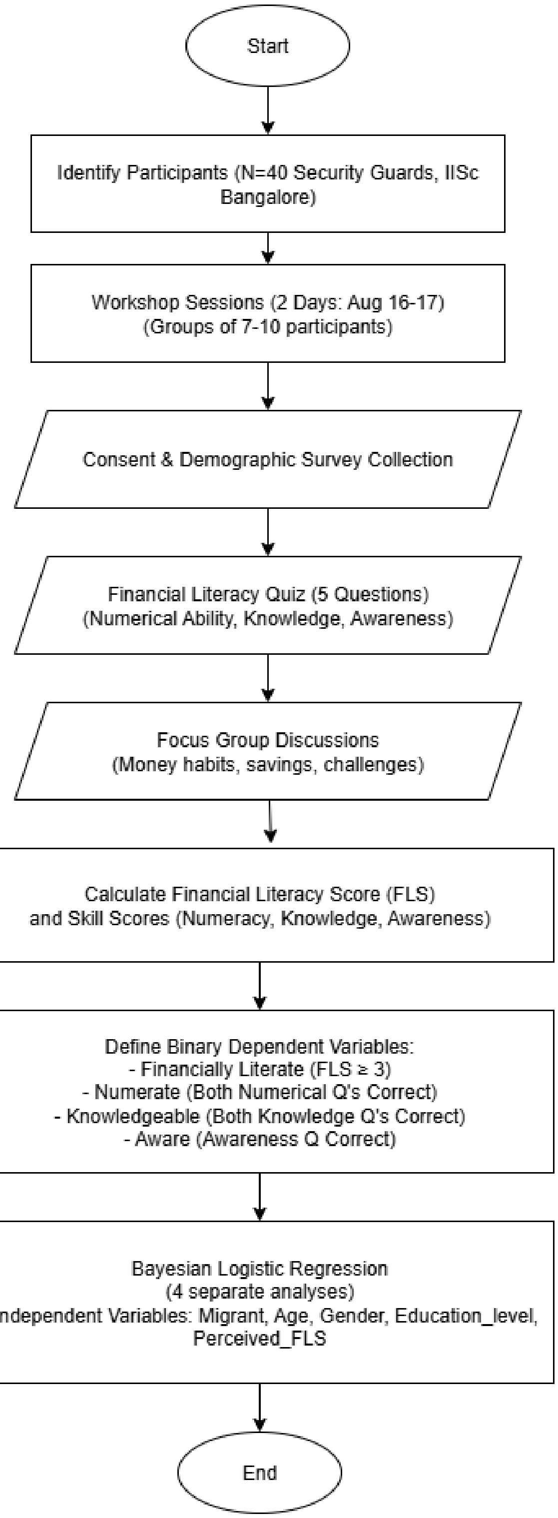

Figure 2

Flowchart of the Financial Literacy Study Methodology